Collaborative Architecture website · guide for the host

For: the developer or host who puts collaborativearchitecture.com online.

Version: 27 October 2026, second package (the complete site in **one zip file**, built from the latest review copy. It replaces the 13 zips sent earlier the same day and adds smoother page changes and picture viewing, and the new Peace Pavilion text on the home page).

In short: the new site is a set of ready-made files: a static site plus two small PHP scripts for the forms.

- There is no WordPress and no database.
- There is nothing to install or compile on the server.
- You upload the folder, add one settings file for the forms, test it, then point the domain at it.

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1. What you are getting

The website comes as one zip file, `CA-website.zip` (225 MB, 804 files). It holds the complete site, with the files at the top level of the zip (no enclosing folder), so it extracts straight into the web root.

In the zip	Contents
The pages and code	**The pages and code:** 67 pages, each as its own `index.html` (`/`, `/work/`, `/work/peace-pavilion/` …), plus `404.html`. Scripts and styles (`assets/`), fonts (`fonts/`), the form handlers (`api/`), `site-config.js`, the icons and `site.webmanifest`. The search files (`sitemap.xml`, `robots.txt`, `llms.txt`, `llms-full.txt`, the feeds, a Markdown copy of each page, the IndexNow key file). The server settings (`.htaccess`, `_redirects`, `_headers`), with 191 redirects from the old WordPress addresses.
`img/`	**The pictures,** in `img/`: the project photographs and drawings, the press covers (`img/cov/` and the `c01-t.webp` files in the project folders) and the share pictures (`img/share/`, 1200 × 630, shown when a page is shared).
`vid/`	**The films.**
`press/`	**The press pages,** in `press/books/` (19 books) and `press/features/` (54 magazine features), as PDF. The project pages, the News page, the site search, the sitemap and `llms.txt` link to these addresses.

If you received the 13 zips (`CA-website-pages-and-code.zip`, `CA-website-pictures-a.zip` …) earlier, set them aside: this one zip replaces all of them, and the separate books, press-covers and share-images zips of older drafts. If the site is already online from an earlier upload, extract `CA-website.zip` over it (files are replaced; nothing needs deleting first).

Inside the site:

File	What it is
`api/`	The two form handlers: `contact.php` (the inquiry form) and `subscribe.php` (the newsletter). `config.sample.php` is the settings template, and `lib.php` is shared code.

File	What it is
`site-config.js`	The settings you can change without a new build: Google Analytics ID, Turnstile key, form addresses.
`press/books/`, `press/features/`	The book pages and magazine features, as PDF. Their names say the year, the publication and the project (for example `2011-retail-design-international-wedge-1.pdf`, `2013-05-society-interiors-studio-profile.pdf`). Keep the names: the site, the sitemap and search engines use them.

Beside the zip:

File	What it is
`nginx.conf`	The same server rules for nginx, if the server is not Apache or LiteSpeed.
This guide	`HOST-GUIDE.pdf` and `HOST-GUIDE.md`.

The same site in one download: the studio's private GitHub repository, `Mumbai-Studio/ca-website`. Ask the studio to invite you.

- The ready-to-serve copy is on the `live-site` branch (*Code → Download ZIP*).
- The source and build tools are on `main`.

2. What the server needs

- **Web server:** any server that serves files over HTTPS.
- Best: **Apache or LiteSpeed with `.htaccess` enabled** (`AllowOverride All`, `mod_rewrite`, `mod_headers`). Most cPanel hosting is like this.
- nginx works with `server/nginx.conf`.
- Netlify and Cloudflare Pages also work, using `_redirects` and `_headers`, but they have no PHP: see 5.4.
- **PHP 7.4 or later, for the two form handlers.** PHP 8.2 or 8.3 is recommended. It needs the `curl` or `openssl` extension, which is standard.
- **About 230 MB of disk space** for the site, and as much again for a short time while the zip is on the server before it is extracted.
- **The site must sit at the root of a domain or subdomain,** for example `collaborativearchitecture.com/` or `new.collaborativearchitecture.com/`.
- It cannot run from a subfolder such as `example.com/new/`, because every link starts with `/`.

3. Before you start: keep the old site

The current site is WordPress.

1. **Back it up in full** (files and database) and keep the backup for at least three months. This is the way back if anything goes wrong (see 10).
2. Do not delete WordPress until the new site has been live for a few weeks. - If the new site goes into the same web root, move WordPress into a folder outside the web root, or keep it as a cPanel backup.

4. Upload

4.1 cPanel, Apache or LiteSpeed (most likely)

1. **Put the site in the web root** of the account the domain will point to (usually `public_html/`):
2. In cPanel's File Manager, open the web root.
3. Upload `CA-website.zip` there.
    - If File Manager refuses a file of this size, upload it with an FTP program (for example FileZilla) into the same folder, then come back to File Manager.
4. Select it and choose *Extract*, into that same folder.
5. Delete the zip afterwards. - The files must sit directly in the web root (`public_html/index.html`, `public_html/work/…`), not inside a subfolder.
6. **Check that the hidden file `.htaccess` arrived.** In File Manager, open *Settings* → *Show hidden files*. This file holds every redirect and security rule; without it the old addresses break.
7. **Check permissions:** folders 755, files 644. These are the normal defaults.
8. **Set PHP 8.x** for the domain (cPanel → *MultiPHP Manager*).
9. **Finish the form settings** (section 5).

4.2 nginx (a VPS)

1. Extract the zip into `/var/www/collaborativearchitecture.com/` (`unzip -o CA-website.zip -d /var/www/collaborativearchitecture.com/`).
2. Use `nginx.conf` (in the repository: `server/nginx.conf`). Set `root`, the certificate lines and the `fastcgi_pass` socket for your PHP-FPM.
3. Then run `nginx -t && systemctl reload nginx`.

4.3 Netlify or Cloudflare Pages

1. Connect the GitHub repository, choose branch `live-site`, leave the build command empty, and set the publish folder to `/`.
2. `_redirects` and `_headers` apply automatically.
3. These hosts do not run PHP; see 5.4 for the forms.

5. The forms

The inquiry form and the newsletter post to `/api/contact.php` and `/api/subscribe.php`.

Inquiries are routed by type:

Type of inquiry	Goes to
Client, Consultants, Research	enquiry@collaborativearchitecture.com
Career	studio@collaborativearchitecture.com
Vendors	vendors@collaborativearchitecture.com

Every message is also kept as a copy in `/_private/` (one file a month). Web access to that folder is refused.

5.1 Settings file (needed)

1. In `api/`, **copy** `config.sample.php` **to** `config.php` and fill it in. - `config.php` holds passwords. It stays on the server only and is never put in the repository. - Automatic deployments never overwrite it.
2. Set `from_email`: the address the site's emails come from. Create `website@collaborativearchitecture.com` in Google Workspace, as a user or an alias.
3. **SMTP (strongly recommended).** Send through Google Workspace so the emails are authenticated and do not land in spam:
4. Sign in to Google as the `from_email` account.
5. Turn on 2-Step Verification.
6. Create an app password at myaccount.google.com/apppasswords.
7. Put it in `smtp.pass`. Keep `smtp.gmail.com`, port 465, `ssl`.
8. If you leave `smtp.host` empty, PHP's own `mail()` is used. That only delivers well if the server's IP is in the domain's SPF record (see 7.3).

5.2 Security check (optional)

The forms already refuse automated messages: a hidden field, a minimum time on the page, and a limit per connection.

For stronger protection:

1. Create a free **Cloudflare Turnstile** widget for the domain.
2. Put the *site key* in `site-config.js` (`turnstileSiteKey`).
3. Put the *secret key* in `config.php` (`turnstile_secret`).

5.3 Newsletter

- **Without Mailchimp settings:** each sign-up is emailed to `newsletter_to` and kept in `_private/newsletter/`, to be added to Mailchimp by hand.
- **With Mailchimp** (an API key and the audience ID in `config.php`): addresses join the audience directly, and Mailchimp sends the confirmation email (double opt-in).

5.4 Hosts without PHP

On Netlify or Cloudflare Pages:

1. Use a form service such as Formspree or Web3Forms.
2. Put its address in `site-config.js` (`contactEndpoint`, `subscribeEndpoint`).

The forms send ordinary `FormData` fields: `name`, `organization`, `email`, `telephone`, `country`, `inquiry_type`, `portfolio`, `message`, `studio`.

5.5 Test the forms

1. Send one inquiry of each type, and check that each arrives in the right mailbox.
2. Subscribe once.
3. Open `/_private/` and `/api/config.php` in a browser: both must answer **403**.

6. Test before the domain moves

The surest test is to see the new server under the real name while the public still sees the old site:

1. **Edit your own computer's `hosts` file** to point `collaborativearchitecture.com` and `www.collaborativearchitecture.com` at the new server's IP.
2. A temporary certificate warning is normal until SSL is issued (see 8).

A subdomain such as `new.collaborativearchitecture.com` also works. If you use one, protect it with a password (cPanel → *Directory Privacy*) so search engines do not index the copy.

Checks:

- [ ] `/` opens: the opening animation, then the home page. On a phone too.
- [ ] Work, a few project pages, Expertise, Lab, Awards, Studio, News, Contact, Privacy, Cookies.
- [ ] Menu, search, image viewer, a project film (Cascadia, National Unity Pavilion), the map view (Work → Map).
- [ ] **A book opens:** on Wedge-1, *Awards and Press* → *Books*, click a cover; the PDF opens in a new tab. `curl -I https://collaborativearchitecture.com/press/books/2011-retail-design-international-wedge-1.pdf` shows `Content-Type: application/pdf` and status 200.
- [ ] The cookie box appears once; *Accept all* and *Essential only* both close it.
- [ ] The inquiry and newsletter forms (5.5).
- [ ] An unknown address such as `/abc/` shows *Page not found*, with status 404.
- [ ] **Old addresses redirect.** For example:
- `/portfolio-item/wedge-1/` → `/work/wedge-1/`
- `/portfolio-item/herman-miller-experience-center/` → `/work/miller-knoll-experience-center/`
- `/publications/` → `/news/press/`
- `/about/` → `/studio/`
- `/wp-admin/` answers 410 (gone)
- [ ] `https://www.…` and `http://…` both redirect to `https://collaborativearchitecture.com/…`.
- [ ] **Headers:** `curl -I https://collaborativearchitecture.com/` shows `Content-Security-Policy`, `Strict-Transport-Security` and `X-Content-Type-Options`.

7. Move the domain (DNS)

If the new site goes on the same server and account as the current WordPress site, there is no DNS change: replace the files in the web root (after the backup) and go to step 8.

Otherwise, follow 7.1 to 7.3.

7.1 Where the DNS is

The domain's DNS is served by the registrar's name servers: `chrisansweb.earth / .mars / .venus.orderbox-dns.com`. That is a ResellerClub (LogicBoxes) reseller panel, so the studio needs that login.

7.2 What to change, and what never to change

1. **A day before:** lower the TTL of the `@` and `www` records to 300 seconds.

2. **On the day:**
3. Change the **A record of** `@` to the new server's IP.
4. Point `www` at the same IP (A record) or at `@` (CNAME).
5. If the server has an IPv6 address, add an AAAA record too.
6. **Do not touch** the records that run the studio's email:

Record	Value
MX (priority 1)	`aspmx.l.google.com`
MX (priority 5)	`alt1.aspmx.l.google.com`
MX (priority 5)	`alt2.aspmx.l.google.com`
MX (priority 10)	`aspmx2.googlemail.com` to `aspmx5.googlemail.com`
TXT	the `MS=…` verification

Take a screenshot of the whole DNS zone before changing anything.

7.3 Email authentication (missing today, add it now)

The domain has **no SPF and no DMARC record** today. Gmail and Yahoo now expect both, so the studio's own emails can land in spam without them.

1. **SPF:** a TXT record on `@`: `v=spf1 include:_spf.google.com ~all`. - If the web server sends with `mail()` instead of SMTP, add its IP: `v=spf1 ip4:SERVER_IP include:_spf.google.com ~all`. - There must be only one SPF record.
2. **DKIM:**
3. In Google Admin → Apps → Google Workspace → Gmail → *Authenticate email*, generate the key.
4. Add it as the TXT record `google._domainkey`.
5. Then press *Start authentication*.
6. **DMARC:** a TXT record on `_dmarc`: `v=DMARC1; p=none; rua=mailto:enquiry@collaborativearchitecture.com`. - After a month of clean reports, move to `p=quarantine`.

8. HTTPS

- Issue certificates for **both** `collaborativearchitecture.com` and `www.collaborativearchitecture.com`: cPanel *AutoSSL*, Let's Encrypt, or the host's own.
- Once both work, `.htaccess` sends every visitor to `https://collaborativearchitecture.com/` without www.
- That redirect applies only on the real domain, so a test address still works over plain http.
- The site sends `Strict-Transport-Security` (one year). Enable HTTPS before going live, not after.

9. After launch

On the day:

- [ ] Repeat the checks in 6 on the real address, from a phone on mobile data as well.

- [ ] **Google Search Console:** 1. Add a *Domain* property and verify it with the DNS TXT record Google gives. 2. Submit `https://collaborativearchitecture.com/sitemap.xml`. It lists the pages and the 71 press PDFs (18 books, 53 magazine features), which Google indexes as documents. 3. Ask for indexing of the home page.
- [ ] **Bing Webmaster Tools:** import the site from Search Console, then submit the sitemap. The IndexNow key file is already published.
- [ ] **Changed pages of 26 October 2026 (IndexNow):** upload `Web copies\seo\96896a9128953f1d84cf614dd721177e.txt` to the site root, then send `Web copies\seo\indexnow-2026-10-26.json` as the body of a POST to `https://api.indexnow.org/indexnow` (`Content-Type: application/json; charset=utf-8`). It lists 101 addresses: the 20 project pages changed that day (Tree of Life, The Barn and The Vessel are new), the Home, Work and press pages, the sitemap, `llms.txt` and the feeds, and the 72 press PDFs. In Google Search Console, request indexing for the three new project pages; Google reads the sitemap's new `lastmod` dates for the rest.
- [ ] **Google Analytics 4:** 1. Create the property. 2. Put the measurement ID (`G-…`) in `site-config.js`. 3. Set data retention to 14 months, as the privacy page says.
- Analytics load only after a visitor accepts them in the cookie box.

In the first two weeks:

- [ ] Watch the server's 404 log and Search Console's *Pages* report. Any old address that still matters gets a line in `server/redirects.txt`; the next build adds it to `.htaccess`.
- [ ] Check Core Web Vitals in Search Console after about 28 days.

10. If something goes wrong (rollback)

- **Same server:** put the WordPress backup back in the web root.
- **New server:** point the A records back to the old IP. With the TTL at 300 seconds, that takes effect within minutes.

Email is unaffected either way, as long as the MX records were left alone.

11. Changing the site later

- **Do not edit the HTML files on the server.** They are generated, and the next deployment replaces them.
- The source is `src/ca-website.html` in the repository; pictures are in `public/img/`, the press pages in `public/press/books/` and `public/press/features/`. The studio requests changes through Claude, which edits the repository.
- **Automatic deployment (recommended):** every change pushed to `main` is built, checked and uploaded by GitHub Actions (`.github/workflows/deploy.yml`). To switch it on, in the repository's *Settings → Secrets and variables → Actions*:
- **FTP (cPanel):**
  - Secrets: `FTP_SERVER`, `FTP_USERNAME`, `FTP_PASSWORD`. Create an FTP account limited to the web root.
  - Variables: `DEPLOY` = `ftp`, and `FTP_DIR` (for example `public_html/`).
- **SSH (VPS):**
  - Secrets: `SSH_HOST`, `SSH_USER`, `SSH_KEY`.

    - Variables: `DEPLOY` = `ssh`, and `SSH_DIR`.
- **cPanel Git Version Control instead:** clone the `live-site` branch into the web root and pull after each change.
- **By hand:** download the latest built site (the run's *site* download on GitHub, or the `live-site` branch as a ZIP) and upload it over the old files. Keep `api/config.php` and `_private/`.

12. Where to ask

- **Website content and decisions:** Mujib Ahmed (studio).
- **Domain and registrar login:** the studio, through the ChrisAnsWeb / ResellerClub panel.
- **Email (Google Workspace admin):** the studio's Workspace administrator.